



SIRE, IT'S A REVOLUTION

THE STORMING OF THE BASTILLE (1789)

IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

The French Revolution

BEFORE

May 1789 Louis XVI summons the States General. In June, the commons forms the National Assembly, taking effective power in the name of the people.

AFTER

April 1792 The Legislative Assembly declares war on Austria and Prussia. The first French Republic is declared.

January 1793 Louis XVI is executed.

March 1794 The Terror is at its peak. In July, Robespierre, its prime exponent, is executed.

October 1795 Napoleon forcibly restores order to a turbulent Paris.

November 1799 Napoleon effectively becomes the ruler of France.

On July 14, 1789, an enraged Parisian mob, seeking weapons to defend their city from a rumored royal attack, stormed the crumbling fortress known as the Bastille and murdered its governor and guards. This violent defiance of royal power has become the symbol of the French Revolution, a movement that not only engulfed France but also reverberated

around the world. The ideas articulated in the revolution spelled the beginning of the end for Europe's absolute monarchies and inspired their eventual replacement by more democratic governments.

The French Revolution originally set out to sweep away aristocratic privilege and establish a new state based on the Enlightenment principles of *liberté, égalité*, and *fraternité*. But although it was introduced by a surge of optimism, the revolution soon degenerated into a violence that played out over several years and that would be brought to an end only by the dictatorship of Napoleon Bonaparte. It remains a story of confusion and chaos, of a collision between a privileged old order, the *ancien régime*, and a new world that struggled, often violently, to create a coherent new order.

A country in disarray

The French king, Louis XVI, well-meaning but indecisive, was hardly the man to confront any crisis, let alone one as grave as that facing France in 1789. In the previous century, his great-great-great-grandfather Louis XIV, the Sun King, had established France as an absolute monarchy, with all power concentrated in the king's hands, and his palace at Versailles as the most sophisticated court in Europe and a bastion of aristocratic privilege.

Louis XVI thus ruled over a country where nobles refused to surrender any privileges, and taxes were paid almost exclusively by an oppressed peasantry: